

Arts-Based Research in Relation to Practical Knowledge in Music Studies

Abstract

*This article examines arts-based research in relation to practical knowledge in music studies in light of the following research question: **What insights can be developed by discussing arts-based research as a scientific method in relation to practical knowledge in music studies, and educational gains of both?***

This serves as the overall research question of this study and has helped me to develop insights and understandings that I will address by dividing the topics of the title into five parts: (a) various understandings of arts-based research, (b) practical knowledge related to music, (c) arts-based research as a scientific method, (d) arts-based research in relation to practical knowledge in music studies, and (e) potential educational gains of both. The last part can be understood as a concluding part in relation to the research question of this theoretical reflexive study. In this part, I argue that the themes are highly relevant to each other, both in terms of methodological approaches to operationalising actions within a performative paradigm, and on a more general philosophical level in terms of facilitating opportunities to offer each other educational gains. The insights developed in this study highlight that the conditions under which knowledge is developed can shape the arrangements that enable and constrain relationships from a practice ecology perspective.

Keywords: arts-based research, practical knowledge, scientific method, music studies, educational gains

This article examines arts-based research in relation to practical knowledge in music studies. The study is based on a reflexive methodology (Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2016, 2018), where insights are developed through hermeneutic interpretation of meaning (Kvale & Brinkmann, 2015) and philosophical hermeneutics (Gadamer, 2008, 2012). I would like to thank the Doctoral Examination Committee for providing a challenging and inspiring topic for my doctoral trial lecture, which guided the research

question of this study: **What insights can be developed by discussing arts-based research as a scientific method in relation to practical knowledge in music studies, and educational gains of both?** Through hermeneutic meaning interpretation and critical reflection on what the core concepts of the study can possibly encompass, I have gained insights that can offer fruitful perspectives at the intersection of arts-based research and practical knowledge by exploring the notions of scientific method, music studies and educational gains. The structure of the text is based on the themes of the title and is divided into five parts: (a) various understandings of arts-based research, (b) practical knowledge related to music, (c) arts-based research as a scientific method, (d) arts-based research in relation to practical knowledge in music studies, and (e) potential educational gains of both.

Theoretical framework of the study

Three tangential theoretical perspectives underpin the basis for developing insights in light of this study's research question: (a) reflexive interpretation; (b) hermeneutic interpretation of meaning; and (c) philosophical hermeneutics. Through reflexive interpretation (Alvesson & Sköldberg 2016; 2018), this study offers insights constructed on the basis of personal, cultural, and linguistic frames of reference that I carry with me as a researcher, as a way of understanding the concepts mentioned, and as a way of offering knowledge articulated as insights. Insights are further developed through a hermeneutic interpretation of meaning (Kvale & Brinkmann, 2015). I find it important to be transparent and acknowledge my subjective interpretation as a researcher, in order to make visible the framework from which different understandings and insights were developed in this study. Furthermore, I find Gadamer's (2008; 2012) concept of philosophical hermeneutics relevant, particularly when it comes to the "art of understanding" (Gadamer, 2008, p. 20) and the idea that knowledge is based on developing understandings and insights rather than explaining truths. Together, these perspectives provide a framework for exploring arts-based research, in this case in the context of a scientific method in relation to practical knowledge in music studies.

Various Understandings of Arts-Based Research

As a backdrop to the study, I will now contextualise it by taking a closer look at different understandings of what the term arts-based research might encompass. So, what is arts-based research? First of all, the term arts-based research is denoted through various nuances, such as ABR, art based research, art-based research (hyphenated), arts based research, and arts-based research (hyphenated). It is also worth noting that these various terms can be understood or interpreted in different ways, such as:

“ABR is a transdisciplinary approach to knowledge building that combines the tenets of the creative arts in research contexts” (Leavy, 2018, p. 4). According to Leavy (2018), arts-based research can serve

as methodological tools relevant to all stages of a study, in other words, as fruitful perspectives for developing new understandings and insights. In Leavy's view, the arts have unlimited potential to educate through the prospect of fostering deep engagement and making lasting impressions. Leavy (2018) also addresses the ongoing debate about whether arts-based research is a research paradigm or a methodological field within the qualitative paradigm. She further proposes arts-based research as an umbrella category that encompasses all artistic approaches to research. At the same time, Leavy (2018, p. 5) emphasises that there are numerous equally valid terms to describe artistic forms of research, exemplified by a partial lexicology of 29 terms for arts-based research, such as: A/r/tography, aesthetic-based research, art-based inquiry, artistic inquiry, arts-informed inquiry, performative inquiry, research-based art, transformative inquiry through art, to name a few. These examples show that arts-based research, like qualitative and quantitative research, represents a transdisciplinary and pluralistic potential of possible approaches to knowledge building by combining arts and research perspectives and contexts.

Rolling (2013) addresses three research paradigms as ways of knowing the world: (a) the qualitative descriptive domain, (b) the quantitative classificatory and statistical domain, and (c) the arts-based domain. He goes on to argue that arts-based research is neither wholly quantitative nor qualitative. It transcends these two paradigms by expanding the range of possible research questions

and the use of methods, and enriches the possibilities for knowledge development. Rolling (2013) suggests this definition of arts-based research:

The multisystemic application of interactive analytical, synthetic, critical-activist, or improvisatory creative cognitive processes and artistic practices toward theory building. Best at addressing questions that can neither be measured with exactitude nor generalized as universally applicable or meaningful in all contexts. Stems directly from a researcher's artistic practice or creative worldview. (Rolling, 2013, p. 8)

Rolling (2013) highlights that arts-based research offers relevant research perspectives by enriching the knowledge pool in terms of different ways of knowing and allowing it to be effectively weighed against other paradigms for theory building and problem solving. Arts-based research can also be understood as a complementary research paradigm from the perspective that all forms of representation are constrained and enabled by the approach chosen by the researcher. Within arts-based research, such approaches could be in the use of visual arts, sound-based arts, embodied arts, creative writing and performance arts as ways of developing arts-based understandings and dissemination. For example, through my study Sonic extractions (Øien, 2021), I experienced a need to explore theory through arts-based research because it offered frameworks that went beyond what the qualitative and quantitative paradigm could offer in the given case. In relation to the experience of Sonic extractions, I find it relevant to highlight Barone and Eisner's definition of arts-based research:

Arts based research is an effort to extend beyond the limiting constraints of discursive communication in order to express meanings that otherwise would be ineffable. . . Arts based research represents an effort to explore the potentialities of an approach to representation that is rooted in aesthetic consideration and that, when it is at its best, culminates in the creation of something close to a work of art. (Barone & Eisner, 2012, p. 1)

According to McNiff (2018), the greatest opportunities and challenges for arts-based research today are to get the key players in the disciplines to believe in it and engage with it, in order to unlock the full potential it has to offer. In the introduction to the first part, 'Art as Research - Opportunities and Challenges', McNiff emphasises that he:

defines art-based research as the use of artistic expression by researchers as a primary mode of enquiry, and discusses the need for applied arts and health disciplines to understand, support and perfect methods of artistic enquiry, thus applying their unique resources to realizing the opportunities preferred by the arts as ways of understanding and communicating human experience. (McNiff, 2013, p. 3)

In addition, McNiff (2013) reflects on how truth can be examined through both fact and fiction and how the unique potential of the arts can both generate evidence and persuasively communicate outcomes or gains.

In the Handbook of Arts-Based Research, edited by Patricia Leavy (2018), McNiff further proposes an operational definition in which he aims to clarify the distinctive nature of arts-based research as: “a process of inquiry whereby the researcher, alone or with others, engages the making of art as a primary mode of inquiry” (McNiff, 2018, p. 24). This definition describes how the research process is operationalised through various forms of artistic expression, and where art is approached as what he refers to as: "a transdisciplinary way of knowing and communicating that is available to every person" (McNiff, 2018, p. 24). McNiff (2018) treats this form of artistic knowledge as an egalitarian and universally accessible process, regardless of academic and artistic level. At the same time, he emphasises that artistic skills affect the quality of study in the same way that specific skills affect all disciplines.

According to Kara (2015), arts-based techniques are particularly appropriate in two areas:

“Arts-based techniques are particularly useful for gathering and disseminating data” (Kara, 2015, p. 24). Kara (2015) points out that a large proportion of creative research methods are arts-based. Furthermore, in pointing out that a large proportion of the arts are also research-based, she turns the concept of arts-based research on its head.

The same perspective is highlighted by Gergen and Gergen (2018), who discuss how scholars influenced by performative work draw on artistic traditions to conduct social science research in ways that can be understood as research-based art. From such a perspective, the distinction between arts-based research and research-based art can be made visible. At the same time, this understanding can shed light on the potential for art and research to shape each other as two parallel growing fields. In the light of Kemmis et al.'s (2014) practice ecology perspective, this can be understood as practices feeding one another, such that the outputs of one practice can be the inputs of the other and vice versa, as a result of a mutual two-way interaction enabled by the interconnections between practices.

So what is arts-based research in education? Cahnmann-Taylor and Siegesmund (2008) address relevant questions in this context. Is it about teachers using the arts in their classrooms, or is it about researchers using the arts with or without participants in their studies? Are we talking about educational researchers working with the performing arts? According to Cahnmann-Taylor and Siegesmund (2008), the short answer to all these questions is: Yes. They elaborate their answer as follows: “Arts-based research in education refers to all the above and probably many other ways in which the arts have moved into the realms of teaching, research, and art” (Cahnmann-Taylor & Siegesmund, 2008, p. 1). On the basis of this understanding, it is conceivable that there are differences between the meanings of the terms arts-based research and arts-based research in education from a contextual perspective. Therefore, when it comes to addressing educational gains, it will be crucial to include the meaning content of both concepts, which I will return to later in this discussion.

The relevance of orienting oneself in the pluralistic range of meanings that the term arts-based research can be thought to contain is, in my opinion, highly relevant and necessary in order to further explore the research question of the study.

Practical Knowledge Related to Music

I will now discuss possible understandings of the concept of practical knowledge before going into more detail about *practical knowledge in music studies*. The concept of knowledge itself will not be discussed, but will be assumed, since the research question of this study focuses on a kind of knowledge that is practical.

Practical knowledge can be understood from different perspectives and can be traced back to the Aristotelian concept of *phronesis*, a concept discussed by Bartlett & Collins (2012) in the literary work 'Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics'. Based on the concept of *phronesis*, practical knowledge can be seen in relation to concepts such as *prudence*, *practical virtue* and *practical wisdom*, as it refers to a type of wisdom or intelligence that is relevant to practical action (Bartlett & Collins, 2012). In this context, wisdom and intelligence are seen as the ability to think and act using knowledge, experience, understanding, common sense and insight. They are also seen as the ability to perceive or infer information and retain it as knowledge that can be applied to adaptive behaviour within an environment or context.

Until the middle of the twentieth century, practical knowledge as a phenomenon was primarily the concern of philosophy and the theory of science. The original meaning of the term implied both good judgement and excellence of character and habits, and was a common topic of discussion in ancient Greek philosophy in a way that is still influential. Today, the term refers to an interdisciplinary field of research that seeks to explore, make visible and validate practical knowledge. Halås et al. (2017, p. 53) highlight that in recent decades the field has particularly focused on professional practice, professional narratives and professionals' reflections on their own practice. According to Halås et al.

(2017), the importance of practical knowledge is now recognised as crucial for the development of professional practice and therefore understood as an exercise of judgement.

From an analytical point of view, Lumer (2010) offers a definition of what practical knowledge is:

Practical knowledge is (defined as)

1. *epistemic condition*: knowledge
2. *empirical condition: effective motivation / internalism*: that, as a central element of a deliberation, actually or potentially, under empirically realizable epistemic conditions, motivates at least a bit to act or to abstain from acting in a certain way and
3. *normative condition: desirable motivation*: that, from a normative (moral or prudential) perspective, should motivate in this way. (Lumer, 2010, p. 2)

Referring to the above definition, Lumer (2010) further writes that: “We need the normative condition 3 because 'practical knowledge' is a practical-philosophical and normative term; without the normative condition 3 it would only be a psychological notion” (Lumer, 2010, p. 4).

Lumer (2010) emphasises that the distinction between knowledge and practical knowledge in this sense depends on the content of beliefs, such as the practical nature of beliefs and whether these beliefs are true or justified. In this context, Lumer emphasises that the concept of knowledge should be used in a sense that implies a justificatory process that leads to beliefs that are true, probably true, or to some extent truthful. In this way, he suggests that beliefs should be a central part of the liberation that links belief and action. To say that a belief motivates or causes action implies a causal relationship that depends on the content of the belief. In other words, to be truly motivating, the belief should be a central part of the deliberation, so that there is more than a rather loose connection between beliefs and actions. Furthermore, Lumer (2010) questions what he sees as the most problematic term in this

definition, namely the concept of 'should', which can be seen in the context of normativity and prudential or moral challenges.

And what about the concepts of 'potentially' and 'empirically realisable epistemic conditions' in this context? These are conditions that, according to Lumer (2010), are intended to significantly expand the set of practical knowledge, in particular to include perceptions that will only develop "motivational force" with the help of additional information and instruction (Lumer, 2010, p. 3). The motivational condition of practical knowledge does not necessarily have to be strong to cause action. However, according to Lumer (2010), motivation cannot be too weak if it is to act as a starting point from which to develop practical knowledge. Relationships between the value predicates that internal and external 'good' in terms of belief content can be identical. According to Lumer (2010, p. 3), this does not necessarily "imply a vicious circularity". Rather, he writes, the proposition by which we determine the extension of 'practical knowledge' can also be motivated and considered as practical knowledge, understood through the concept of circularity.

According to Lumer (2010), a key aspect for knowledge to be considered practical is that such knowledge must be related to action in order to lead or motivate action, otherwise the knowledge would not be practical. The above definition suggests that such a relation to action can be interpreted empirically or normatively according to the following two conditions "practical knowledge motivates" and "practical knowledge should motivate". How such a view of practical knowledge in music studies can be understood in relation to arts-based research, I will return to later in this discussion.

Furthermore, what is (practical) knowledge in relation to music? Music and knowledge can be understood in different ways, and according to Elliott (1991) music as knowledge can be a concept rich in possibilities. Elliott emphasises the importance of performance or practical activity in music education. This understanding is expressed in the statements:

Music, at root, is what musicians know how to do. On this view, the art of music is both a form of knowledge and a source of knowledge. For it is the art of music that potential music makers

must learn. And to the aspiring music maker (performer, improviser, composer, arranger, conductor, and so on) music is the body of knowledge that is the source of what he or she will know. More broadly, and as I will attempt to explain in a moment, musical performing offers an even more fundamental kind of knowledge. (Elliott, 1991, p. 23)

Elliott (1991) further illuminates the potential of the thinking-doing relationship through the concept of musicking. Elliott addresses the concept of *musicking* as a multifaceted interaction in which thought and action serve as interwoven aspects in non-verbal manifestations of thinking and knowing. In other words, musical *know-how* can be thought of as a continuum between what can be demonstrated in action and what can be fully explained in words. By considering music as both verb and noun, Elliott (1991) conceives of musical performance in educational contexts as something worth doing for its own sake, recognising music as a *form* of knowledge and a *source* of knowledge.

Practical knowledge in music studies may also presuppose theoretical knowledge in certain contexts, and thus Aristotle's trichotomy, referred to by Bartlett and Collins (2012) as *phronesis*, *techne* and *episteme*, can be mentioned as a potential prerequisite. Angelo et al. (2019) highlight that policy changes and higher education reforms are challenging performing musician programmes across Europe, further leading to a constant academisation of arts education. In this view, practical knowledge in music studies cannot be seen as isolated from other discourses of knowledge, as practical knowledge in music studies differs from other traditions of knowledge construction in that it is positioned at the intersection of multiple views of knowledge, in a broad sense. This perspective is consistent with Elliott's (1991) understanding of music as both a verb and a noun (see also Small, 2006), in the sense that knowledge can be developed through the performer's use of thinking in action, knowing in action, and reflecting in action.

The following discussion aims to provide a critical reflection on what the concepts presented might stand for when related to each other. Can arts-based research be considered a scientific method? How can arts-based research be understood in relation to practical knowledge in music studies? And

what educational benefits can arts-based research and practical knowledge in music studies offer each other? **These are the questions I would like to discuss.** In the tension between arts-based research and practical knowledge in music studies, there are both tangential and contradictory perspectives. First, I will reflect on arts-based research as a scientific method. As mentioned earlier, there is an ongoing debate about whether arts-based research can be understood as a scientific method or as a research paradigm in its own right. The significance of arts-based research may depend on parameters other than those within the quantitative and qualitative paradigms.

Arts-Based Research as a Scientific Method

Arts-based research can be seen as an artistic way of developing knowledge and communicating in education. According to McNiff (2018), these can be primary modes of practice understood through performative action. McNiff (2018) discusses artistic inquiry in a way that can position this field as both a paradigm and a method when he encourages researchers to: **“present, a reasonable and convincing alternative paradigm based in the arts; and demonstrate how artistic inquiry and experimentation can generate useful and effective approaches to an area of practice or problem”** (McNiff, 2018, p. 27). The relevance of such an agenda depends on a mutually established respect to participate and contribute to fruitful research discourses, and by focusing on enriching the researcher's possibilities and approaches to knowledge development in any given context. **Furthermore, McNiff (2018) suggests that the same extends to the place of the arts in research, as he highlights the extensive critique from dominant research paradigms that discredits and marginalises research that does not fit into more established frameworks.** In a Gadamerian view (Gadamer, 2012), different epistemological foundations and worldviews cannot be imposed, but rather take place through the concept of the fusion of horizons, where in encountering other people and the outside world one can facilitate mutual exchange of understandings as a basis for knowledge development.

According to Leavy (2018, p. 8), artistic practices share many similarities with qualitative research in that both practices can be seen as craft. Furthermore, Leavy asserts that arts-based research can provide new insights and learning across a range of topics by:

ABR offers ways of tap into what would otherwise be inaccessible, makes connections and interconnections that are otherwise out of reach, asks and answers new research questions, explores old research questions in new ways, and represents research differently and to broad audiences. (Leavy, 2018, p. 9)

So perhaps the central question in this context is not whether arts-based research should be considered a scientific method, but rather to consider all possible approaches so that we are not deprived of potential opportunities for knowledge development. Extending the understanding of music through the present participle form of music - namely *musicking* - this can be thought of as a research response that offers the notion of knowing to form continuous tenses of what the concept of *knowing* or *know-how* could potentially entail. This discussion leads to new questions as well as answers, and perhaps it is as interesting to encourage new reflections as it is to offer explanations within a field that tends to explore ways of developing understandings.

We can also question arts-based research as an appropriate umbrella term, and the discussion of arts-based research as a methodological direction within qualitative research or a unique paradigm can still be problematised. Especially as the starting points for these questions are often based on frameworks drawn from already established research traditions. Developing understandings of the nature of arts-based research may require new approaches to explore opportunities and potential.

As discussed earlier, the question of methodology versus paradigm may be contextualised and dependent on individual understandings of what concepts such as multimethodology or methodological pluralism, performative craft and skills, and practical knowledge in the arts might entail. McNiff (2018, p. 28) problematises the distinction between the concepts of science and research

by arguing that research is larger and more inclusive than science alone. Thus, arts-based research can be understood as a research method as well as a scientific method. And perhaps the crux of the question of whether arts-based research is a practical, interactive, heuristic line of research, a research method, a scientific method or, more generally, a procedure or approach, has practical value without being justified as being valid in principle. Perhaps it is precisely because of the nature of the arts that fruitful frameworks for arts-based research can be developed - and perhaps research principles can be applied to arts-based research based on the premises of the arts themselves. In this way, arts-based research can stay ahead of the conventional and challenge norms.

Arts-Based Research in Relation to Practical Knowledge in Music Studies

In this part I will reflect on how arts-based research can be understood in relation to practical knowledge in music studies. Practical knowledge in music studies, as discussed earlier, is associated with musical action and processes involving the performance of music.

Gergen and Gergen (2018) address performativity by discussing the performative movement in interaction with established research paradigms. In a research discourse that includes the arts, arts-based research can be recognised on the premises of the arts as well as the principles of established scientific methods. This does not necessarily mean that arts-based research cannot be considered a scientific method, but rather that the frameworks that define the qualities of scientific methods are challenged and expanded through mutually respectful dialogues. And all of this, of course, depends on the uniqueness of art being recognised as a potential research approach. With such a view of research, the spontaneity and emergence of the arts and artistic practices can create space for processes of discovery that enable practical knowledge development through the use of arts-based research. Such processes of inquiry require and involve researchers who engage with the arts as a way of knowing, represented by research practices informed by the belief that the arts and humanities can facilitate social science goals and outcomes. Thus, arts-based research can be seen as a scientific method as well as a paradigm and philosophical approach to developing practical knowledge. Although performative

research may require some artistic experience that presupposes certain skills, practical knowledge in music studies can be developed over time in the face of arts-based research at both a performative and reflexive level. From such a position, arts-based research can be understood as a reasonable approach to developing practical knowledge in given contexts, as exploratory ways of acting and thinking. It is conceivable that there are different implications if ABR is seen as (a) a method; (b) a paradigm; or (c) a philosophical approach; or (d) a combination of these. The implications for the researcher, for research design and for the development of knowledge will be addressed in more detail in the next part of the discussion.

Potential Educational Gains of Both

So, what are the potential educational gains at the intersection of arts-based research and practical knowledge in music studies? I take the term 'both' in the research question to refer to the terms 'arts-based research' and 'practical knowledge' in the context of music studies. Based on the different definitions of arts-based research and practical knowledge mentioned earlier, the concepts can be understood as tangential fields, but also as two sides of the same coin. Given that arts-based research and practical knowledge in music studies are seen as knowledge based on practical activities, which the concept of musicking allows, both can be understood as actively performing practices where know-how is developed through experience-based music studies. In this way, these concepts represent a potentially high degree of relevance to each other, both in terms of methodological approaches related to operationalisation within a performative paradigm, as well as on a more general philosophical level in terms of facilitating opportunities to offer each other potential educational gains.

In order to understand the possible benefits that can arise from the interplay between arts-based research and practical knowledge in music studies, Kemmis et al.'s (2014) theory of ecologies of practices can offer perspectives to inform the discussion. According to Kemmis et al. (2014, p. 47), there is an organic connection between practices in that practices can 'feed' each other. In this context, if we understand practical knowledge as action in the form of processes of music-related work, and

arts-based research as a practical performative approach to music studies, it is conceivable that these practices have the potential to inform one another. The outputs and gains of practical knowledge can thus be the inputs of research and vice versa. In this way, it is possible to imagine that the conditions that enable the development of knowledge may shape the arrangements that enable and constrain the relations between practices.

If the arts can influence learning in educational contexts through the concept of musicking, focusing on both product and process in relation to thought and action, the performative artistic action can go beyond the actual making of music and create further deep impressions. Such a view can be further elucidated by Leavy's (2018, p. 6) thoughts on advances in the understanding of art and learning as pervasive and central to human thought and action, also from a neuroscientific perspective. Leavy (2018) notes that research in the neuroscience of the arts is an expanding area of research. Based on this research, Leavy (2018, p. 7) concludes that our brains respond in critical ways when we engage in art making and consumption, when we enter creative flow zones.

Research practices can be put into play and at stake by and with each other, and possible pedagogical gains from the relationship between arts-based research and practical knowledge in music studies can be operationalised at the intersection of performative work and research. Performative work is a field that, according to Gergen and Gergen: "radically alters, and perhaps expands, the definition of knowledge and research" (2018, p. 63). In the search for knowledge, it is conceivable that by challenging conventions and norms, research using performative perspectives can move away from the idea of developing truths towards developing understandings. In this way, everything can remain open to questioning, so that realities are dissolved in such a way that new approaches to knowledge development become possible.

These reflections on arts-based research as a scientific method in relation to practical knowledge in music studies, and the potential educational benefits of both, may hopefully stimulate further discussion in light of the challenges and opportunities raised. By challenging and blurring the lines and boundaries between research traditions and paradigms, we can gain new insights into the

development of knowledge and ways of thinking and being in artistic, research, teaching and learning practices (see also Øien et al., in review). This concludes my contribution to the ongoing discourse within the multifaceted fields of arts-based research, practical knowledge, music studies and education.

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